Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Dawn Leas's "why it is a sin to kill a mockingbird"

Literary concepts that MIGHT—**however, in a discussion of characterization, the contestant might not use any of these terms**—be used by the contestant, include

alliteration,
anthropomorphism,
assonance,
asyndeton,
audience,
character,
characterization,
consonance,
diction,
didacticism,
dynamic character,
enjambment,
ethos,
feminist criticism,
free verse,
imagery,
metonymy,
moral criticism,
onomatopoeia,
pathos,
persona,
rhetoric,
setting,
simile,
speaker,
synecdoche,
synæsthesia, and
tone.

The contestant's response should exhibit the qualities of a good, formal essay. The thesis statement should be supported by evidence from the poem itself, preferably directly quoted.

The response, as directed by the prompt, should be a response to Leas's poem, **not to Lee's novel**. The response should **not** be—as directed in the prompt—a comparison between the poem and the novel.

Implicit in the didacticism that colors the poem are society's expectations of a good father and his responsibilities, as well as the expectations inherent in a father's raising of a self-sufficient daughter. The strong essay will, in following the prompt, address ***either*** the father's character ***or*** the daughter's developing character, perhaps vis-à-vis the ethical proposition symbolized in the poem's title, which is, of course, derivative of the aggregate moral foci of the novel.